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Benchmark

Verbal Identity

Visual Identity

Brand Book

External Evaluation

Use of AI

Brief

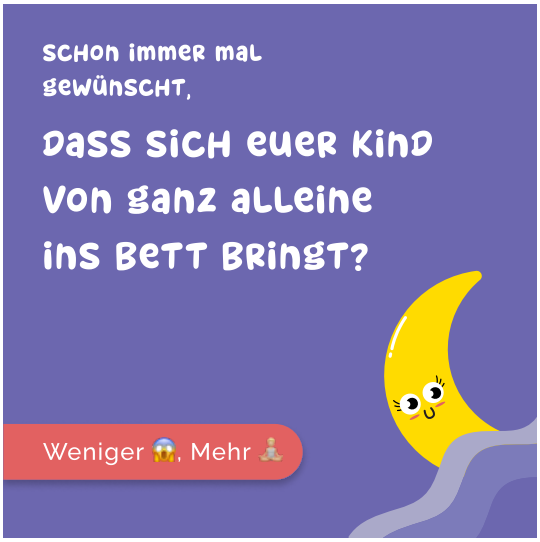
Context

We (Moritz Donaubauer, Sarah Rahabi and Max Pinkert) started our project in February 2026 as part of our orientation semester at CODE University of Applied Sciences. After initial research and ideation we set ourselves the following mission:
We are developing children products to empower them with their day-to-day routines. Our first product is called Schlafsteine and aims to help children with following their bedtime routine on their own.

Brief

Building on the initial idea and product direction the challenge is now to broaden the scope and draft a brand that acts as an umbrella for products like Schlafsteine. The brand uses Schlafsteine as first inspiration. The expected results are an applicable and relevant brand. Meaning the deliverables include a brand core suitable for the target audience, a visual and verbal identity backed up by ready-to-use assets and first examples of how to apply the brand.

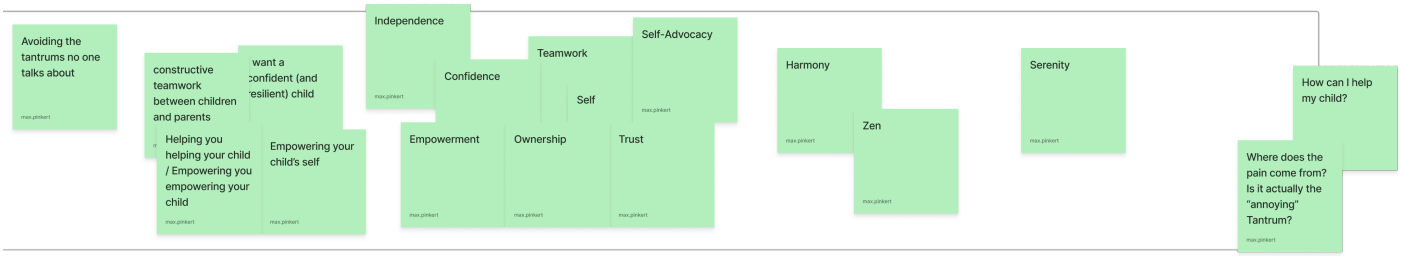
Artefacts

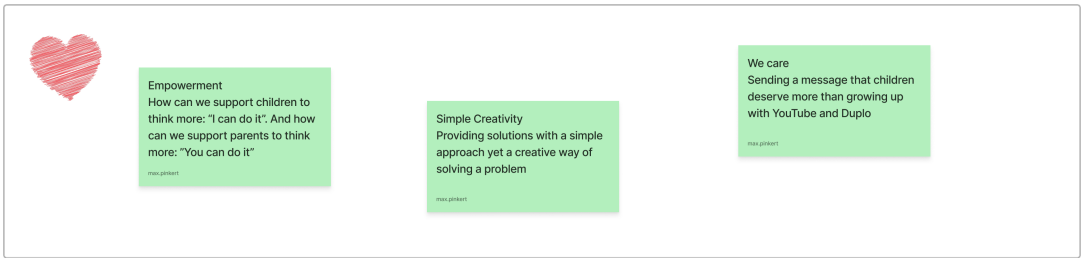


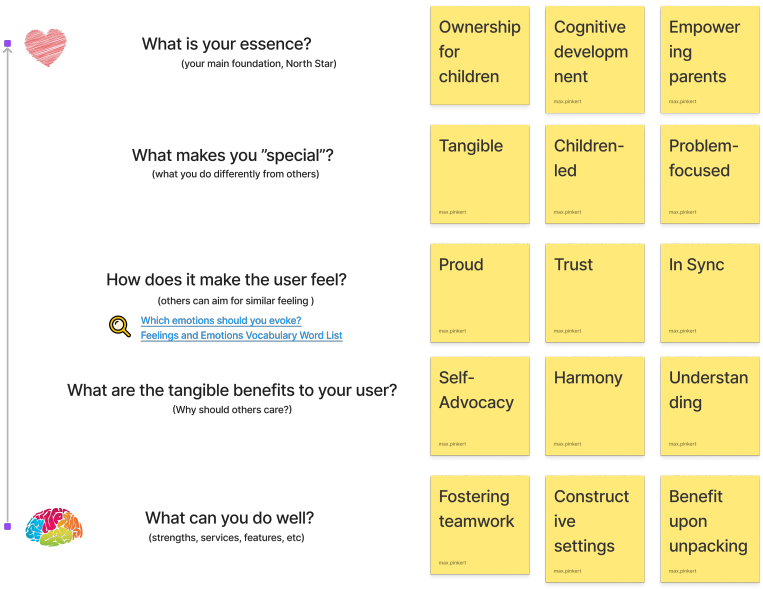
The brand isn't build from scratch but takes into consideration the previously designed artefacts as part of the product exploration for Schlafsteine.

Core

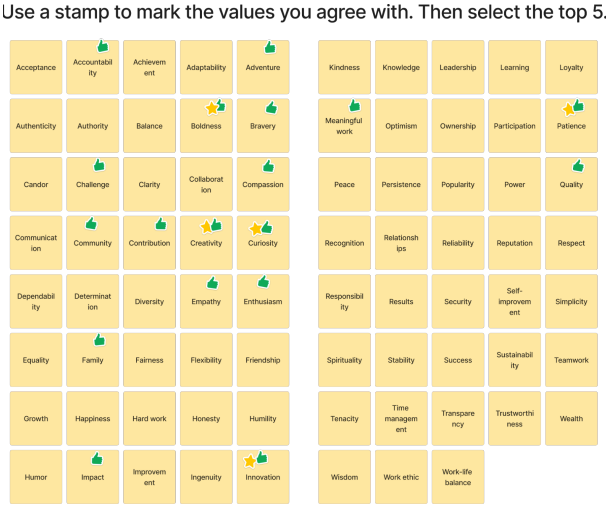
I started with a lot of brainstorming of what this “umbrella” could be and what I generally think of where a children brand could thrive.

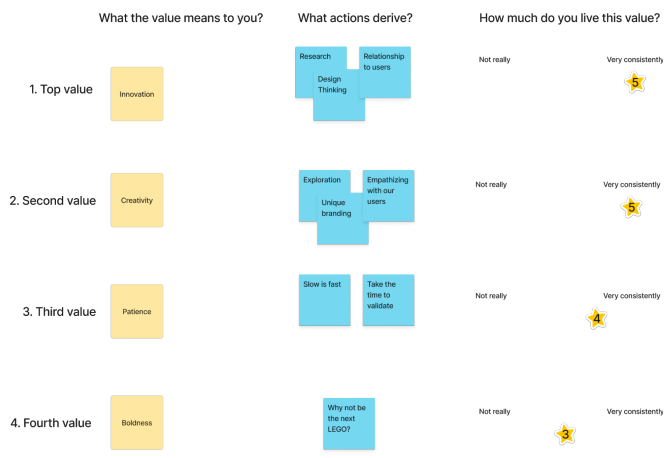






Use a stamp to mark the values you agree with. Then select the top 5.





Evaluation

After brainstorming my personal ideas for the brand, I went to our team and asked for their opinion on values.

Value #1 — Innovation

Research | Relationship to users | Design Thinking

Not really — Very consistently: 5

Value #2 — Creativity

Exploration | Empathizing with our users | Unique branding

Not really — Very consistently: 4

Value #3 — Patience, Responsibility

Slow is fast | Take the time to validate

Not really — Very consistently: 4

Value #4 — Boldness, Impact

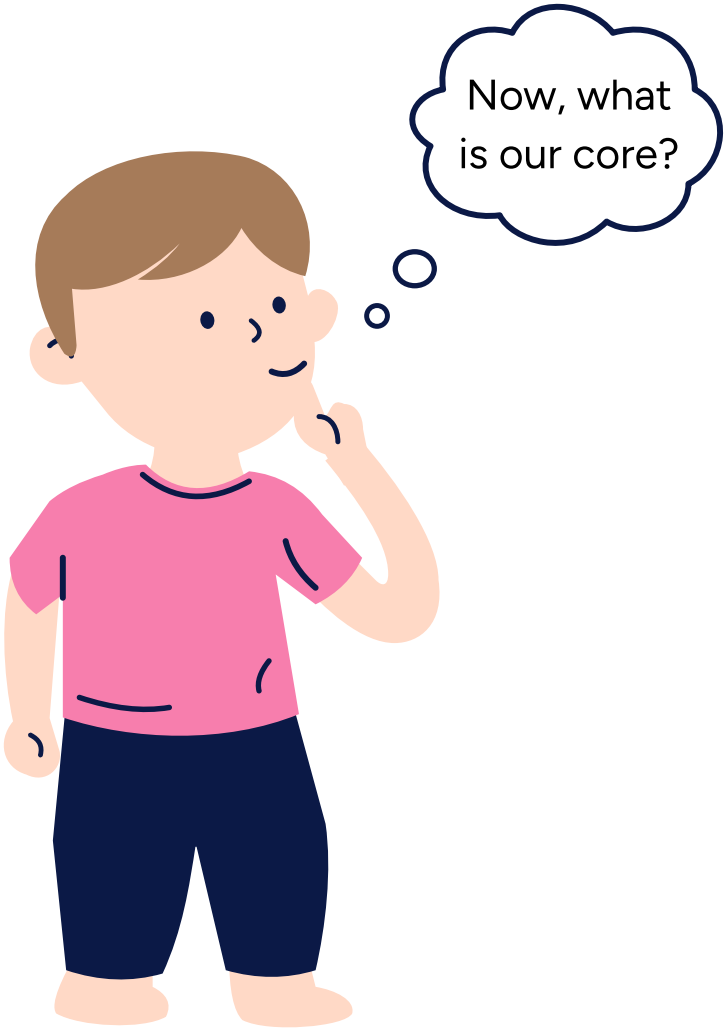
Why not be the next LEGO?

Not really — Very consistently: 3

Value #5 — Learning, Growth, Family

How can we support the growth of children | How can we enable families?

Not really — Very consistently: 2


Now, what
is our core?

Patience
As with the development of children, we responsibly embrace the process of creating valuable products

Simple Creativity
Simple out-of-the-box yet creative solutions to solve problems

Problems First
We start at the problem.

Impact
We confront the attention-seeking children products and replace them with child-led empowerment

Growth
We empower families in their growth and development.

Values

Taking all the different approaches towards defining the brand core, I tried to find patterns and recuring themes. I personally also hate non-unique values, meaning being very specific of what we are and not just “We are a sustainable company.” I started with the values as they had the clearest direction from our internal evaluation.

Vision & Mission

Next I looked at the more pragmatic and shorter term statements for vision and mission to hopefully find my way towards our brand core.

Vision

Creating the next generation of confident people

Mission

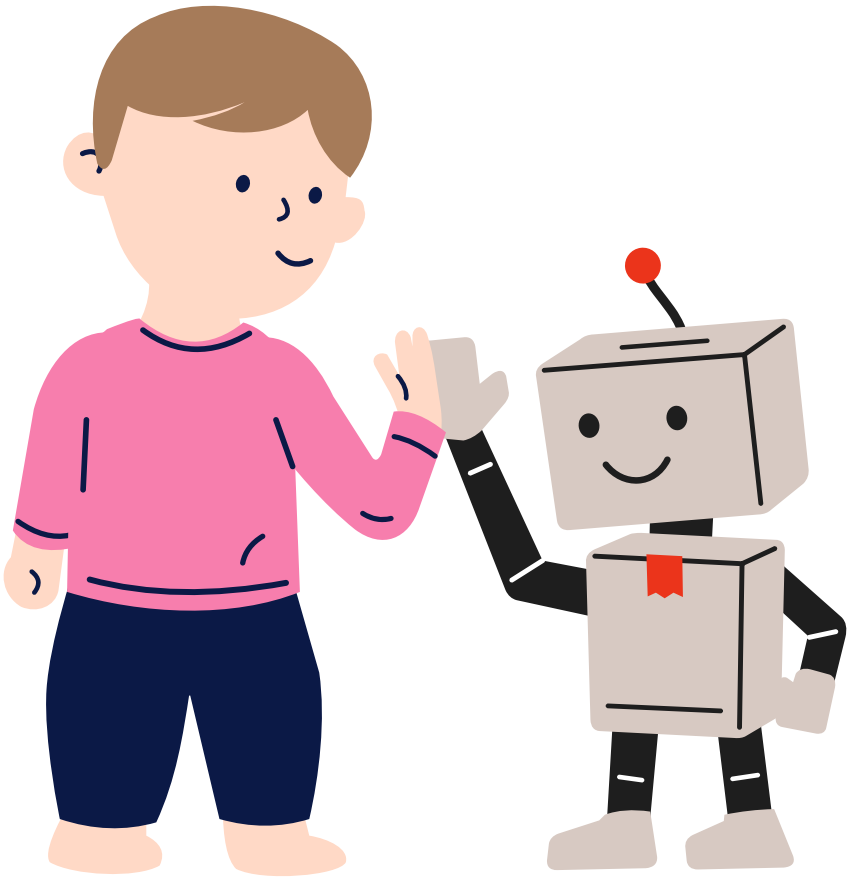
Understanding problems in the upbringing of children and the development of their cognitive skills. Addressing these problems with simple yet creative innovations.

We care.
Sending a message that children deserve more than growing up with YouTube and Duplo

max.pinkert

Brand Core

Which each step I more and more found what I was looking for: We care. It sounds stupid and simplistic and all the things I didn't want to achieve as it is very interchangeable. In what we're trying to achieve it felt right though. Because we want the simplicity of putting on a YouTube video to calm everyones nerves but we want it without the guilt. And currently looking at the market for children and parents, there are only a few brands that both have simple products yet products with a purpose. Plus, without doing much research, it feels like screen-free children products are on the rise, meaning parents do want something else than YouTube, they just don't have access to it yet. To go even further, we don't want to stop there but actually provide more value than "As long as the child plays with something, I'm happy". That's why we're taking a swing at toys like Duplo, because we don't just want to create another toy but care about providing valuable input for the development of children.



To nail this down, clean up all loose ends and polish this into something usable, I created BRAND.md. This is supposed to help humans and non-humans grasp the brand and apply it across various scenarios and applications.

BRAND.md

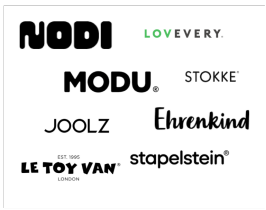
What
now?

Mooooodboard

I was fairly lost at this point. I had a clear idea of the brand but not at all what it would look like, feel like, talk like...
When I started a moodboard to explore directions, I basically had nothing, a few images, a few impressions from visiting toy stores in Berlin but nothing to build upon or nothing as a foundation to inspire the visual and verbal identity. So I decided to look what others are doing and hopefully finding bits and pieces I enjoy. I collected a list of 33 more or less competitors or at least brands in the field of children and explored each brand regarding colors, fonts, visuals, products and elements I want to save as inspiration.

Imagery

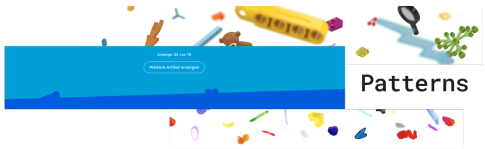
"Ich bin schon groß!"



Colours

Textures

"Ich kann das!"



Patterns

"Du schaffst das!"

Imagery

Benchmark

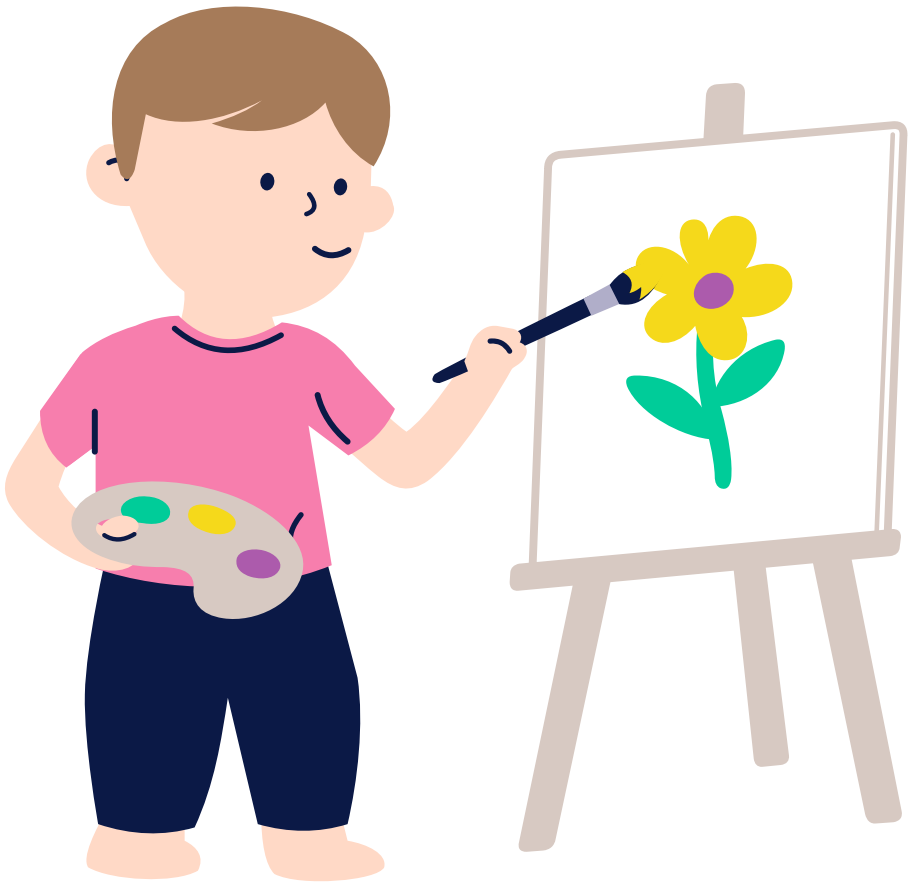
The exercise of finding inspiration from competitors and children brands fruited less than I hoped it would. Nonetheless I took away some learnings:

- All the colors! There is only one clear pattern regarding colors and that is: All of them are being used. Either all at once or one brand uses blue and one brand uses red.
- Evaluating a children brand based on their website only gives a limited picture of how they position their brand.
- Very few brands have a careful and consistent design.

Extracted color palette of all brands and their colors...

Some elements as inspiration

Let's start designing!



What to call it?

As with every great project, I first had to find a name! I ran a first try following the proposed ideation process and ended up with grooos. Why?

- I wanted a word that in itself represents our brand. “Groß” reminded me of my daughter standing in front of me and telling/showing me how tall she already is.
- I wanted a word written in the way children would pronounce it. So not “Groß” but “gros”.
- I wanted to add the proudness factor of a child, that they aren’t just “gros” (tall) but “groooooos” (taaaaalll).

I was very confident with that name and after a first internal evaluation we also felt fairly happy with it. BUT, there is always a but...

You’re reading this in English so you might have already tripped when hearing the word “gros”. So after a short consideration, it was clear that we don’t want our brand to be associated with “disgusting”.

Yet, the core elements: representation, child pronunciation, and proudness factor, stayed valid. So just had to find another typical sentence a child would say in a situation where they feel big/tall/old/confident/proud. Honestly, didn’t have to look far, to think of this sentence:

Guck mal, ich kann das schon selber.
(Look, I can do it myself.)

Retrospectively an even better fit to our brand, as it shows the result of empowering children: confidence to do it themselves.

Selbaaaaaaaa was born.

Who is it?

To understand how we want to communicate, I first needed to understand who selba actually is. Let's imagine selba as party guest:

They don't talk much, they listen, putting others at center stage and not themselve. They are discrete yet funny to loosen up any tension or formalities. Their hope is to have everyone be themselves. They have a background in education yet they don't walk around telling everyone that.

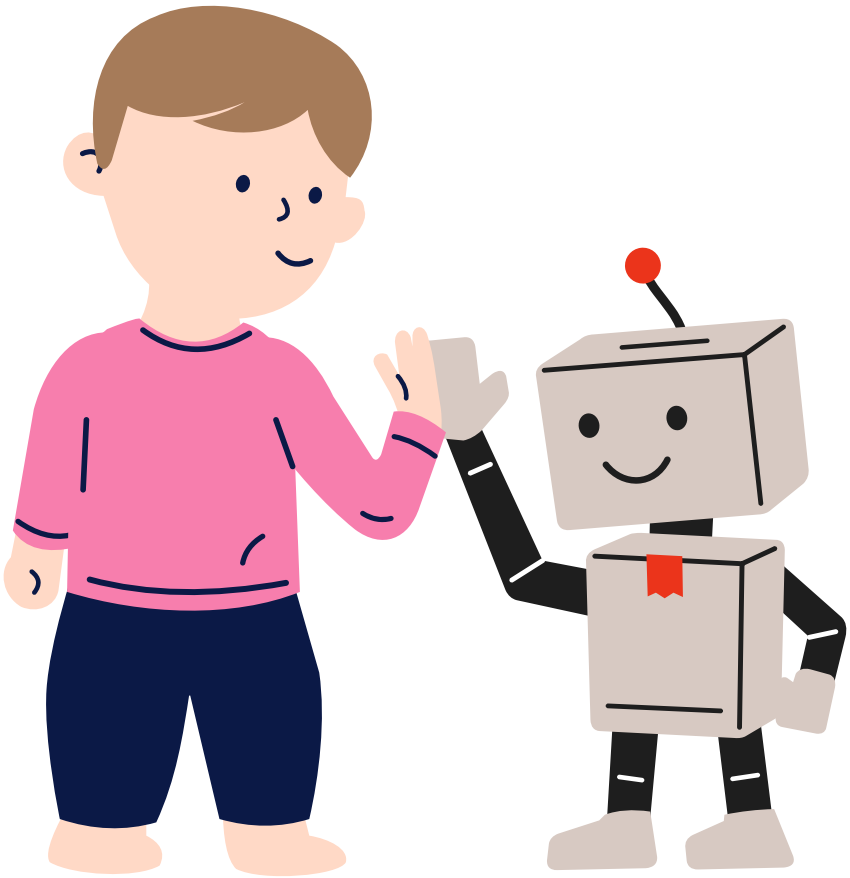
Now what would mean that for our communcation, how would that reflect in our tone and voice?

Trait	Description	Do	Don't
Caring & Patient	Our voice should sound like someone who is genuinely interested in engaging with the stakeholder.	Check-in with the stakeholder. Leave room for questions and feedback and thoughts.	Monologue.
Trust	Research-backed content. Generalistic educational guidance.	Leave room to create own opinions and interpretations.	Educate parents.
Tension-less	We losen up the conversation to avoid unnecessary formalities.	Use humour with care. Be aware of the humour preferences of the stakeholder.	Be too goofy. Be too flat/plain with the jokes.

Dimension	How to address it
Funny vs. serious	We lean towards funny and switch to serious if stakeholders are uncertain.
Formal vs. casual	Casual while avoiding acting or presenting the brand as amateur
Respectful vs. irreverent	Respectful in the way we address stakeholders to help them open up to us.
Enthusiastic vs. matter-of-fact	Depends on the stakeholder, for children we need to be enthusiastic, for parents we need a solid foundation.

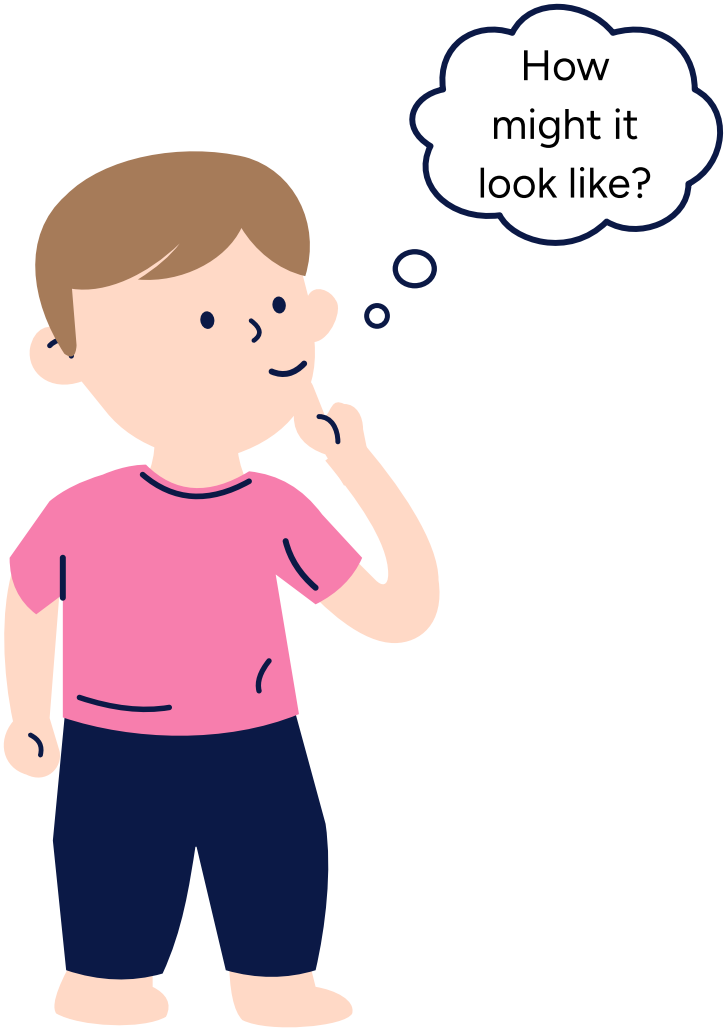
Next to the main traits, we need to trade off the different dimensions. How funny are we? More formal or more casual?

The resulting direction:
Our language should give people room to decide, and occasionally something to smile at. The combination is the voice. No individual word, joke, or sentence pattern has to appear in every message.



I want to make it easy for everyone both humans and non-humans to apply our tone and voice in their copywriting. For this the user can either familiarize with tone-and-voice.md or use AGENT.md to seek a little helper for their copywriting.

tone-and-voice


How might it look like?

Remember this one?

Back to the benchmark and it was clear, that we don't necessarily have to stick to a few colors. But I also wanted to position us with one key color to be recognized by. And in addition the initial brief requested to being able to act as an umbrella, meaning for colors I also had to acknowledge how they would scale across products. Meaning:

- Primary color
- Scalable color palette in harmony with the primary color
- Don't be afraid of multiple colors.

And this was the first result, one primary color and a palette per time of day to reflect the mood and vibe per day time.

When I tried a few applications of the colors, I stumbled upon two difficulties:

- The primary morning color is tough to combine with white/black text.

- The day color isn't vibrant enough as primary color.

So taking those two improvements, I switched the morning blue to the primary morning color and the day coral as the primary color for day.

Primary
#EB341B
CMYK(0,78,89,8)

Ink
#1E1E1E
CMYK(0,0,0,88)

Screen
#FFFFFF
CMYK(0,0,0,0)

Morning
#499ACD
CMYK(64,25,0,20)

pink
#F77EAD
CMYK(0,49,30,3)

sun
#F5D91B
CMYK(0,11,89,4)

lime
#EB341B
CMYK(0,78,89,8)

Day
#FF7852
CMYK(0,53,68,0)

purple
#AC5BAC
CMYK(0,47,0,33)

torqouise
#00CC99
CMYK(100,0,25,20)

blue
#18498F
CMYK(83,49,0,44)

Night
#0B1946
CMYK(84,64,0,73)

lavender
#B0AEC9
CMYK(12,13,0,21)

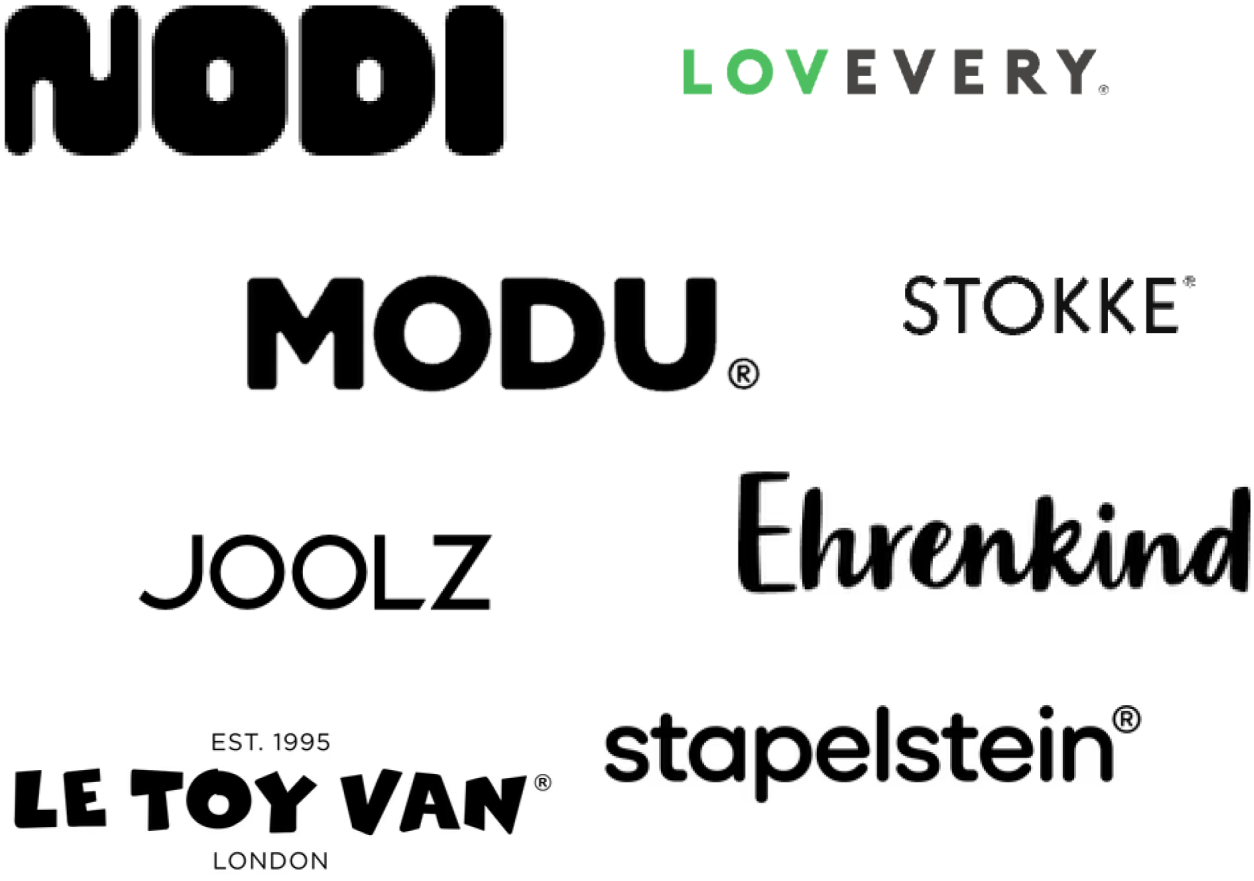
sand
#D7C9C2
CMYK(0,7,10,16)

sage
#BDDC9F
CMYK(14,0,28,14)

We want to see the logo! Logo, logo, logo!

Now that the colors are set, the next big topic was to find a logo. From my moodboard and my benchmark work, I was inspired to go with something simple as I didn't want to use the logo as a primary visual. And it also was clear, that is has to suit to lots of colors.

- Simplistic logo
- Black and white version
- Big readable font



Let's take a vote!

I created a few first direction and let the team vote, which direction they preferred (green dots):

FONT-BASED WORDMARK

INCORPORATING "STONES" OR OTHER TOYS

CLEAN, SOFT AND SLIGHTLY PLAYFUL

CHAOTIC

CRESCENDO

EXPLANATION MARK

COLORS

RESPONSIVE DESIGNS

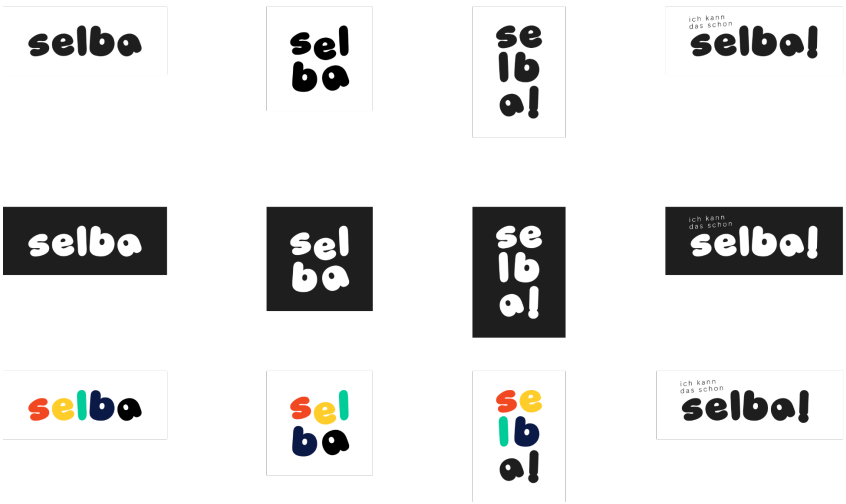
**This was still with the first version of the color palette.*

Final iterations

Taking the directions from the voting, I created a final set of iterations to nail down the logo:

ITERATIONS

FINAL DRAFTS



**This was still with the first version of the color palette.*

Logo, logo, logo!

The final set now includes a black, white and colored logo with a few compositions to allow it to fit various layouts:

Had to dim the lights for these ones...

selba

selba

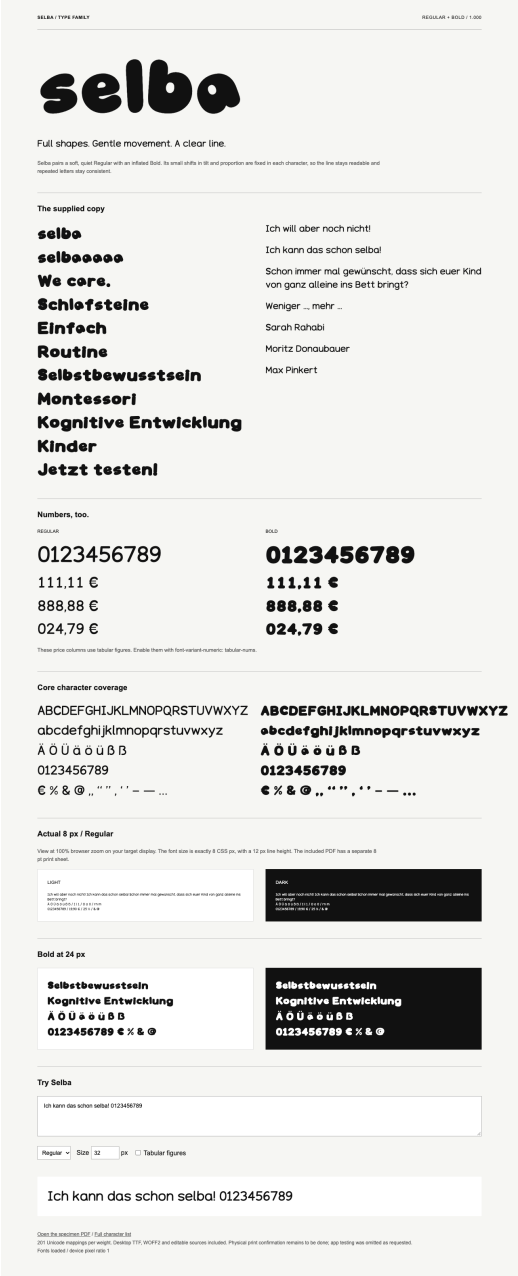
selba!

Foundations are set!

Logo check, name check, colors check, tone and voice check, check, check, check!? Ah wait a minute, this text, what font is that?

We make our font selba!

The font-style logo made we wonder if I could create a font based on the logo. So I asked my little helper if it could create a font and obviously it answered: Sure, happy to do that. So running through some iterations and fine-tuning some letters I'm happy to present: Selba

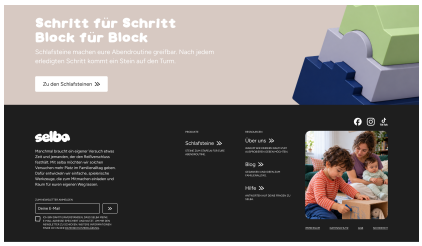


Originally created as a font family, with a Bold and a Regular weight, I quickly realised that the Regular font in application looked too much like Comic Sans. As a backup I had originally planned to use Figtree as body font anyways. So the font pairing, also check: **selba** + Figtree

Let's
apply it!

Website

A first easy brand test: a website. So I tried to create a couple of components based on the visual direction. Here some impressions:

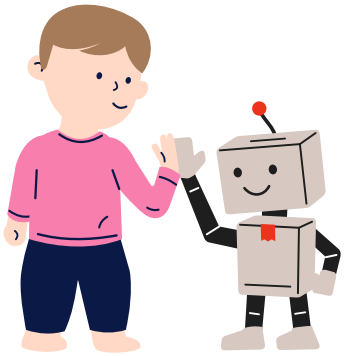


see for yourself

Mooooore

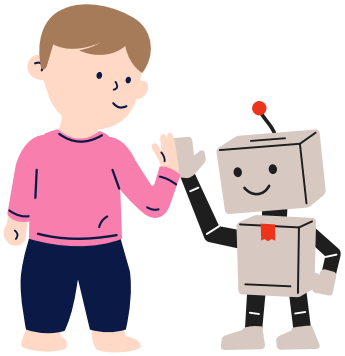
While applying the brand, I ran into more and more gaps regarding missing assets, just some examples of what I created along the way:

Wait a minute!



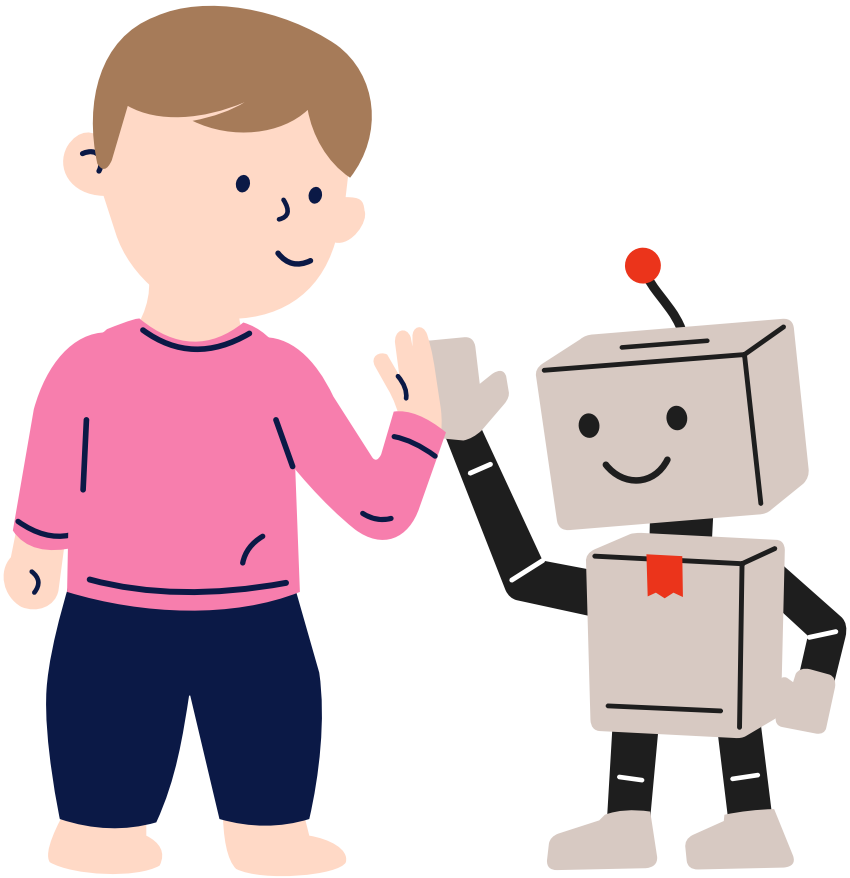
In a teamwork effort my little helper and I created a guideline plus a skill to create on-brand images, as currently there isn't any budget to hire actors for these, the fallback for on-brand images had to be images created by image-generation models.

imagery



And to bring those images to life, I decided to include small graphical elements to enhance our images. And to allow everyone to create those without needing to jump into Affinity or Adobe Illustrator, there is also a guideline and prompt to create those on top of brand images.

illustrations



Aaaand on the topic of images and illustrations, the little girl and boy are also the result of a prompt. It uses three baseline illustrations each and can create a boy and/or a girl for whatever activity is needed.

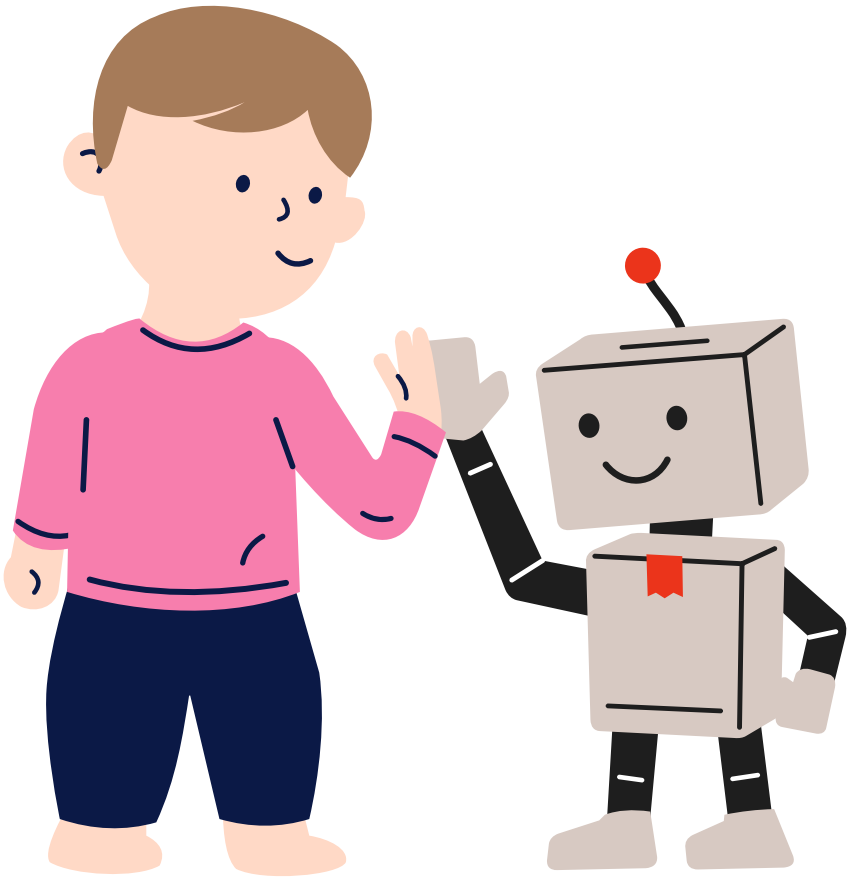
skill to create girl and/or boy

Where
were we?

Brand book!

All the assets, guidelines, visual identity and verbal identity are now in a structured brand book. It captures everything you need to know to apply the brand.

Explore the Brand Book



One last note on working with your little helper on brand assets and applying the brand (and also because I just really fell in love with the cute robot, so I had to use it one more time):
Everything I presented is in a GitHub repository, meaning you can just present it to your little helper of choice and it will find the relevant applications and assets.

Brand repository

I wonder,
what others
might think?

😮‍💨 Evaluation

Once the brand book was done, I wanted to check in with our target audience or at least the ones that can read fluently: parents.
I used the reactions proposed by the NN Group derived from the Microsoft Desirability Toolkit*:

- Boring
- Busy
- Calm
- Cheap
- Creative
- Cutting-edge
- Exciting
- Expensive
- Trustworthy
- Familiar
- Fresh
- Impressive
- Innovative
- Inspiring
- Intimidating
- Old
- Professional
- Unprofessional

As our target audience is in Germany, I translated them to German to avoid any losses in translation. I requested feedback from solely parents to use target-audience-relevant feedback.

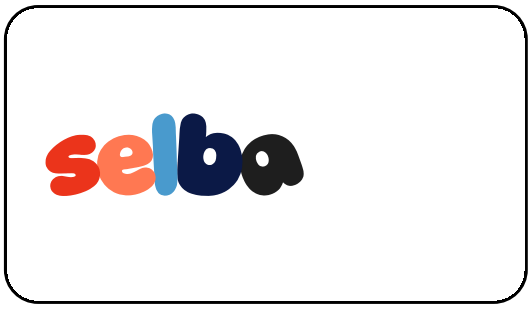
And to also test the persona prompts (probably forgot to mention this, here you go) I ran the same brand survey with them.

Next to capturing their reactions to a few brand assets, I included two additional questions to see what they would associate the brand with.

Let's focus on the results with the humans:

*Moran, K. (2016, February 28). Using the Microsoft Desirability Toolkit to Test Visual Appeal. Nielsen Norman Group. https://www.nngroup.com/articles/microsoft-desirability-toolkit/

Survey



Alt	3
Neu	2
Erfrischend	2
Langweilig	1
Kreativ	1
Vertrauenswürdig	1
Professionell	1
Teuer	1
Vertraut	1
Hektisch	1
Günstig	1

Vertrauenswürdig	5
Erfrischend	2
Professionell	2
Spannend	2
Vertraut	2
Neu	1
Inspirierend	1
Kreativ	1
Innovativ	1
Teuer	1
Ruhig	1

Langweilig	4
Ruhig	3
Kreativ	2
Günstig	2
Innovativ	1
Alt	1
Spannend	1
Teuer	1

Erfrischend	3
Vertrauenswürdig	3
Spannend	3
Vertraut	3
Ruhig	3
Kreativ	2
Professionell	2
Inspirierend	1

*6 responses in total

Survey

ORIGINAL

Nachdem du nun ein paar Eindrücke von unserer Marke erhalten hast, wie würdest du selba deinen Freunden in zwei Sätzen beschreiben?

Selba macht schlafsteine für Kinder welche aufeinander aufbauen und aus dem 3D Drucker kommen. Sie wirkt sehr vertraut und unaufgeregt.
Ohne etwas darüber zu wissen: eine Marke die Kinder in ihrer Selbstständigkeit bestärken soll und durch gezielte Produkte Kreativität fördern möchte.
schwierig, Konzept ist mir noch nicht ganz klar
Selba passt mit seinem Design zum Zeitgeist. Die Marke strahlt eine gewisse Ruhe aus.

Was denkst du, welche Produkte selba anbieten würde?

Innovatives Kinderspielzeug mit hohem Lernpotenzial.
Schlafsteine, Produkte für Kinder, eher entspannt und ruhig um Kinder runterzubringen, weniger aufregend.
Bausteine, Montessori Spielzeug, Produkte die den Alltag von Kindern erleichtert und sie selbstständig werden lässt.
konnte ich nicht richtig verstehen.
Ich denke, die Marke möchte Ordnung in Kinderzimmer bringen und bietet Staumöglichkeiten an, die spielerisch umgesetzt werden, damit Kinder "selba" tätig werden.

*6 responses in total

Survey

TRANSLATED

Now that you've gotten a sense of our brand, how would you describe it to your friends in two sentences?

Selba makes building blocks for children that stack on top of each other and are produced by a 3D printer. She comes across as very approachable and unhurried.
Without knowing anything about it: a brand that aims to empower children to be independent and foster creativity through carefully designed products.
Difficult, the concept isn’t entirely clear to me yet.
Selba’s design fits the spirit of the times. The brand exudes a certain sense of calm.

What do you think selba would offer?

Innovative children's toys with high educational value.
Sleep Stones, products for children, more relaxed and calm to help children wind down, less exciting.
Building blocks, Montessori toys, products that make children’s daily lives easier and help them become independent.
I couldn’t quite understand that.
I think the brand wants to bring order to children’s rooms and offers storage solutions that are designed in a playful way so that children can get involved on their own.

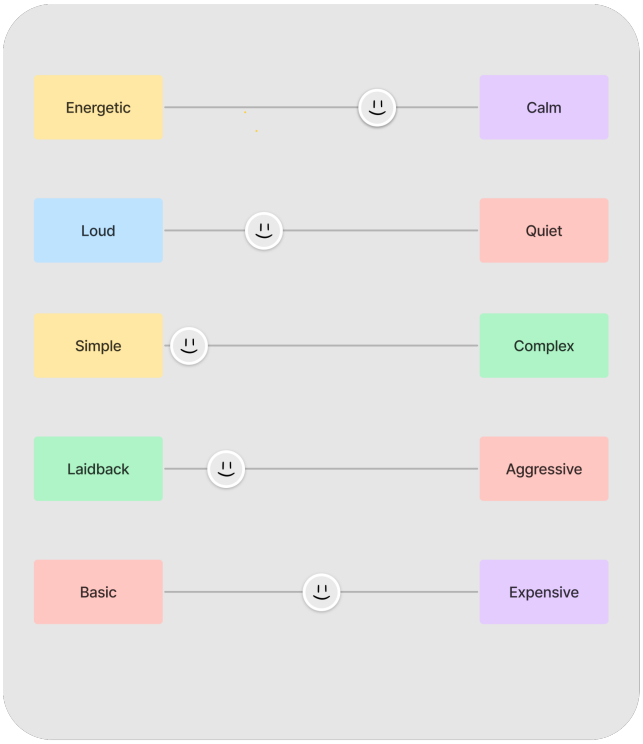
*6 responses in total

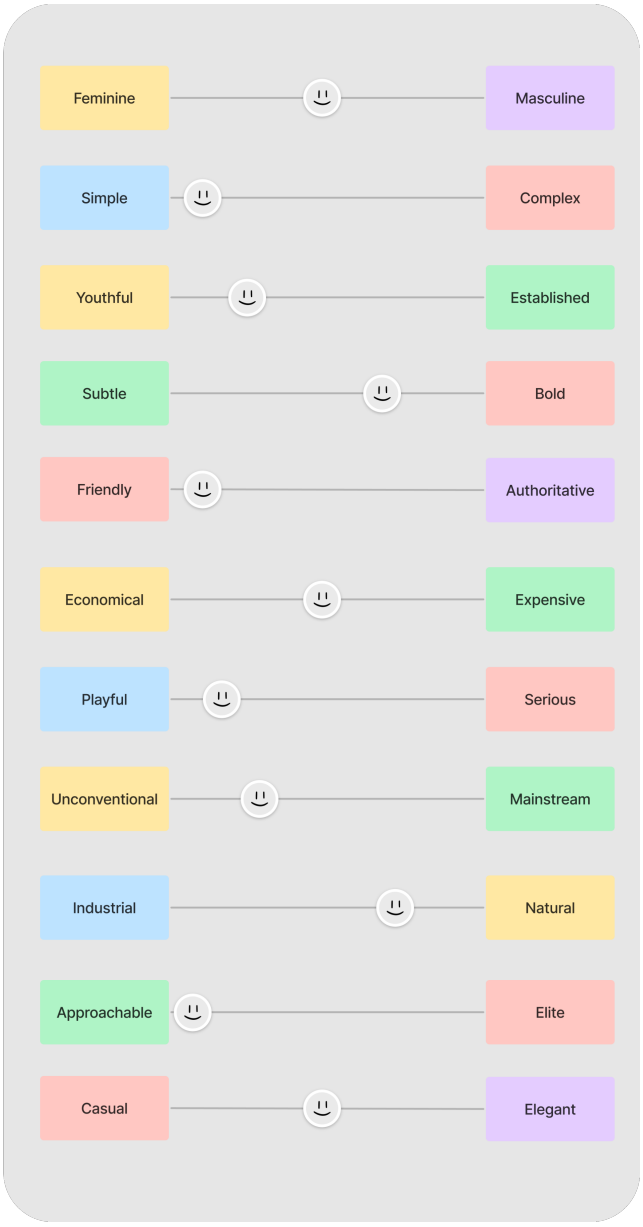
Learnings

I didn't have any expectations or ideas how our target audience would react. My hope with the brand was to tick the boxes for:

- Calm
- Trustworthy
- Familiar
- Innovative or Creative
- Professional

Based on my initial brand mood:





😮‍💨 Learnings

The logo, website, product and imagery was reacted to differently. My biggest concern was for the imagery and website, as the website asset best applied my idea of how the brand should communicate in advertisement and the imagery the kind of emotions it should communicate. The product asset was meant to be a baseline check of how update-needy this asset is and for the logo, I had to test it, even though it isn't my primary visual, it should at least not fully conflict with the overall brand reaction.

Logo
Highest ranked were both Old (3) and Young (2), with maybe a direction towards young as Fresh (2) was right up there as well. Apart from these multiple were rated with 1 vote. Happy to see Professional and Trustworthy among them but concerned to see Cheap and Hectic included as well.

Website
I'm very relieved to see Trustworthy voted 5 out of 6. At 2 votes each it is also great to see Fresh, Professional, Exciting and Familiar up there. The reactions with one vote complement that picture, only Expensive isn't necessarily what I hoped for but to be fair, better than Cheap.

Product
Seeing Boring (4) and Cheap (2) up there is probably not what you hope for with a product design. Yet the product isn't meant to be Exciting, as it tackles the area of bedtime routines and not day-time activities. So seeing Calm (3) in there is a relief. Out of all the assets, I would still say, this one isn't aligned to the brand yet.

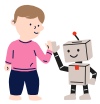
Imagery
Considering that all these images were created by a prompt, it is a compliment to the prompt to achieve Trustworthy (3) and Familiar (3) as high ranked reactions. It seems to be perfectly on brand with the additions of Fresh (3), Exciting (3) yet Calm (3) all receiving high ranks and even Professional (2) being voted as reaction.

😮‍💨 Learnings

My biggest takeaways are:

- The logo needs a more thorough feedback to understand how it could be improved to align with the brand.
- The website seems to be spot on.
- The product could probably align better to the brand but it’s design has to primarily fit it’s intended use and purpose. Maybe it needs the packaging to bridge the two design directions.
- The imagery is surprisingly spot on. Which is great for the initial assets to not have to rely on professional real-life shots.

The evaluation helped me to create some confidence for the initial version of the brand. Yet, these were only 6 persons and even with the 6, looking at the logo and the product, it became clear that the brand can be further improved. For now, I’m happy with how the target audience reacted and next iterations should take this first feedback as starting point to further polish the brand.



I referenced the little helper a few times, so here some examples where I used an LLM or the Figma Agent to tackled the deliverables:

What are things/methods/tools parent might use to bring their child to bed? And I'm more focused on the steps to get there, e.g. brushing their teeth and putting on their pyjama. here my list so far:
Die kleine Raupe Nimmersatt, Toniebox, Peppa Pig / Bluey, Schlafberatung, Montessori
Think broad, generally looking at educational toys/tools/methods for children, for example expanding to competitors like LEGO, Ravensburger (tiptoi, games...) and Lovevery

Extract the color palette of ...

create 30 logo variations for the children brand named "selba", feel free to include more "a"s at the end or an explanation mark to support the underlining message of "I can do it myself" or in German "Ich kann das selber (children pronounce: selba)". I want a simple wordmark as logo, start with only black and white, no or little graphics or illustrations. make 30 distinct ones to test different directions and intentionally overpowering the direction

here is what I have so far. the font is meant to be used primarily for the logo, titles and highest hierarchy level text elements. its supposed to be this bloated font, plain but a bit off to acknowledge the imperfections of for example a children handwriting. I need upper and lowercase for German. the weight is the attached thickness, I would call it bold. in addition I want a less thick weight as Regular. use these paragraphs as test ground:
Bold:
selba
selbaaaaa
We care.
Schlafsteine
Einfach
Routine
...

help me write a guideline for imagery for our brand:
/Users/max/Documents/GitHub/selbaaa-brand-book/BRAND.md
Write it to a new .md file and use the attached image as an example I would approve.
Here my input to the guideline:
One of our core drivers is confident children. So in our imagery I want to see children in their "natural" habitat, meaning activities they enjoy, not looking at the camera but in their imaginary world and focused on their activity. with that kind of the idea of let kids be kids.
if parents are depicted, they play a supporting role.
The imagery needs to suit our color palette which itself is divided by our product ranges for Day, Morning and Night. so the imagery also has to reflect the different moods depending on the product range they are used in. if no range is defined, it should default to day:
/Users/max/Documents/GitHub/selbaaa-brand-book/assets/colors/digital.md
What I like about the attached picture is seeing the kids focused with a slightly happy face, a bright color palette, natural light but not too warm, surrounding "chaos", meaning its rarely in real life just a kid with a book and pencils, they are normally surrounded by the natural mess around them, be it something to eat or drink, "leftovers" from the previous activity or their siblings and other clutter, that they don't care about.
In conflict with the attached images, our imagery will focus on scenes indoors.
Our imagery will contain our products, but they should naturally fit into the scene and not overpower it. with the images we want to communicate the emotions and not a polished product image.
Include a prompt to generate images according to our imagery guideline. placeholders for it are Morning/Day/Night, age group of depicted children, image(s) of product to include. it should always create a range of pictures with the same children and the same apartment, so that the user can work with more than just one picture.
Don't assume anything for this guideline, ask me clarifying questions if you have any gaps and apart from that use best practices examples of imagery guidelines, feel free to research those

Recap

From Brief to Brand Book to Evaluation, I hope this document has shown my process. Here the key material, I have mentioned and I haven't mentioned yet:

Process

Design System

Brand repository